

Appreciation - A Song of Poykayil Appachan

A song of Poykayil Appachan is a powerful poem that voices the pain, resilience, and historical consciousness of Kerala's marginalized first people. Appachan, also known as Sree Kumara Gurudevan, was a pioneering Dalit leader, social reformer, and founder of the Pratyaksha Raksha Deiva Sabha. Through this poem, he challenges the dominant historical narratives that have erased the experiences of the oppressed communities and asserts the need to reclaim their forgotten past. One of the greatest strengths of the poem is its critique of history. Appachan points out that there are many "histories," yet none records the lives and struggles of his people. The use of the plural word "histories" is significant because it suggests that history is not a single objective truth but a collection of narratives shaped by those in power. By exposing the absence of his race from these narratives, the poet questions the authority of mainstream history and demands recognition for the earliest inhabitants of the land.

The poem also highlights the importance of writing and documentation. Appachan laments that no one wrote the history of his people, leading to their exclusion from collective memory. This absence is not merely accidental but reflects the social and political marginalization of the oppressed. The poet recognizes that written history is a source of power and identity, and therefore seeks to reclaim that space by narrating the story of his own race.

Another remarkable feature of the poem is its rejection of shame. The poet openly declares that he is not ashamed to reveal the weaknesses of his race because the stigma attached to them is created by an oppressive social order. Society has branded his people as a "cursed progeny," but Appachan refuses to internalize this prejudice. Instead, he exposes the injustice behind such labels and transforms what was once considered a mark of inferiority into a symbol of dignity and resistance. This bold rejection of imposed shame makes the poem a powerful statement of self-respect and social awakening.

The language of the poem is simple, direct, and emotionally charged. Rather than relying on ornate imagery, Appachan uses plain yet forceful expressions that communicate the lived realities of discrimination and exclusion. The sincerity of his voice and the intensity of his emotions make the poem deeply moving. Every stanza reflects his determination to recover the erased history of his people and to question the structures of caste and racial oppression.

The final stanza adds a philosophical and spiritual dimension to the poem. Appachan questions how God, the creator of all human beings, can allow such injustice and racial discrimination to continue. This is not merely a religious question but a moral challenge to society. The poet's appeal to God reflects both despair and hope—the despair of witnessing endless oppression and the hope that justice must ultimately prevail. The concluding question leaves readers reflecting on the ethical responsibility of humanity to eliminate discrimination.

The poem is also significant for its historical and political relevance. Recited in the Legislative Assembly of Tiruvithamkoor in 1921, it transformed poetry into a form of social protest. Appachan's words became a voice for those who had long been denied representation, dignity, and justice. His contribution extended beyond literature to the democratization of Kerala's society and politics. In conclusion, It exposes the silence imposed on marginalized communities, challenges dominant versions of history, rejects the politics of shame, and calls for justice and equality. Poykayil Appachan's powerful voice continues to inspire readers to question social hierarchies and recognize the importance of preserving the histories of those who have long been excluded. The poem remains a timeless reminder that true history must include every community and every human experience.

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